

BEFORE

Long-distance trade across Eurasia was stimulated by the demand for luxury goods—precious metals, spices, and silks—by the wealthy inhabitants of powerful empires.

EARLY TRADING LINKS

In Europe and Central Asia, the empires of Persia << 92–3, Greece << 94–9, and Rome << 110–15 opened up **communication and trade** as far east as the kingdoms of India. In the east, the **Qin and the Han dynasties << 126–29** unified China. In 138 BCE the Han emperor Wudi sent Zhang Qian to seek allies to fight their enemies to the northwest of China. The knowledge he brought back of kingdoms to the west led to the opening of **new trade routes**. A network of trading links soon developed between East and West. Silk reached Rome from Han China through a series of intermediaries, principally the Parthians << 122–23.

TRADING IN IDEAS

Flourishing in India from the 3rd century BCE, **Buddhism traveled** north to Central Asia and then east along the Silk Road to China, where it was firmly established by the 4th century CE.

ALTERNATIVE TRADE ROUTES

Following the rise of Islam << 174–77 Arab traders used the seasonal **monsoon winds** to build up an extensive seaborne trading network around the Indian Ocean. In the

8th century CE they even found a **sea route to China** and traded directly with the **Tang << 160–61**. It must have been on the ships of Arab traders that Chinese goods from this era were transported to the east coast of Africa.



CHINESE VASE
FOUND IN AFRICA



New world view

Narratives of 13th- and 14th-century travelers transformed European maps of Asia. This image of the Silk Road from the *Catalan Atlas* (1375) possibly shows Marco Polo traveling in a caravan.

Banditry and political instability were a constant threat to the routes that made up the Silk Road. It was in periods of relative peace, during the rule of the Tang dynasty (see pp.160–61) and later under the protection of the Mongols (see pp.164–65), that trade along the Silk Road truly thrived.

The empire of the Mongols

By 1250, Genghis Khan (see pp. 164–65) and his successors had conquered an area that stretched from the Yellow Sea to the Black Sea. Under Mongol protection the Silk Road flourished as a 4,000-mile (6,400-km) trade route, along which travelers and traders were able to move in unprecedented safety.

Kublai Khan (see p.165), who became Great Khan of the Mongols in 1260, later declared himself emperor of China. He founded the Yuan dynasty

that would rule China until 1368 and established his court at Dadu (modern-day Beijing). Before the 13th century, the idea of a journey from Europe to China was unheard-of, but taking advantage of the Silk Road, a few merchants and missionaries traveled all the way to Kublai Khan's capital. They included the Venetian merchants Niccolo and Maffeo Polo, who reached Dadu in 1266. There were apparently well received by the Great Khan, who wanted to learn about Christianity and Western science. Five years on, Niccolo and Maffeo's nephew, Marco Polo (see right), reached Kublai's court. Also in the 13th century, Rabban Sauma, a Chinese Christian, made a pilgrimage in the opposite direction, from Dadu to Jerusalem, and then on into Western Europe. The accounts of both journeys provide a fascinating glimpse into life along the Silk Road in medieval Asia.

Traffic of treasure

Silk was not the only valuable commodity traded along the Silk Road: there were spices, medicines, ivory, rare plants, exotic animals including leopards, and precious stones such as amber and lapis lazuli. Commodities from the west included textiles, gold, and silver. From China, caravans carried silk, paper, weapons, lacquer, and even rhubarb. Goods were sold or exchanged for other commodities en route in staging-post bazaars.

The products were carried on camels, horses, bullocks, and yaks, depending on the location. The two-humped Bactrian camel was Central Asia's hardiest beast of burden. It could withstand the searing heat and biting cold and survive without water between oasis towns. Great caravans plied the Silk Road, and camel trains of 400 animals were not uncommon.